The sequel is due next year, alongside a spate of faith-based dramas: two films on Hanuman, including one made entirely using artificial intelligence; a film on Kali; and an animated feature on Parashuram, among others.

## Leap of Faith

**The success of *Hanuman Ansh* follows what has already** been a noteworthy year for devotional cinema. In January, *Laalo – Krishna Sada Sahayte* became the highest-grossing Gujarati film of all time, earning Rs 100 crore plus. Made by a crew of debutants—from director Ankit Sakhiya, lead actor Karan Joshi, composer Smmit Jay to lyricist Prem Dave—the film germinated from Sakhiya's need to advocate goodness and bring god into regular conversation. "I felt that when I was with friends, I could not talk about god. It was not seen as cool but old school," Ankhiya told INDIA TODAY earlier this year while promoting the release of the Hindi-dubbed version in Mumbai. The film sees Krishna saving its angry, alcoholic titular protagonist and setting him on a spiritual journey.

May saw another Krishna film, *Krishnavataram Part I: Hridayam*, make Rs 40 crore. Much like *Hanuman Ansh*'s Shobhinaw, it was a breakthrough role for Siddharth Gupta, who plays Krishna. "I was spiritually aware but not inclined when the project came to me," he says. "It's when I started reading the Bhagavad Gita and other scriptures that the responsibility I was being bestowed with dawned on me. The process takes you away from its result." These days, Gupta's friends don't swear in his presence lest they offend 'Kanhaji'.

The ball had been set rolling the previous year. Hombale Films' *Mahavatar Narsimha* emerged as the surprise blockbuster of 2025, netting nearly Rs 250 crore in its theatrical run against a budget of just Rs 15 crore, and single-handedly giving the Indian animation industry a massive impetus. It was first-time filmmaker Ashwin Kumar's attempt to address what he felt was a vacuum of stories celebrating Hindu mythology and culture. " If a crore people can visit Kumbh mela, you know there is a colossal mass that loves stories on faith. We just need to bring them tales they truly believe in, and do it with self-belief."

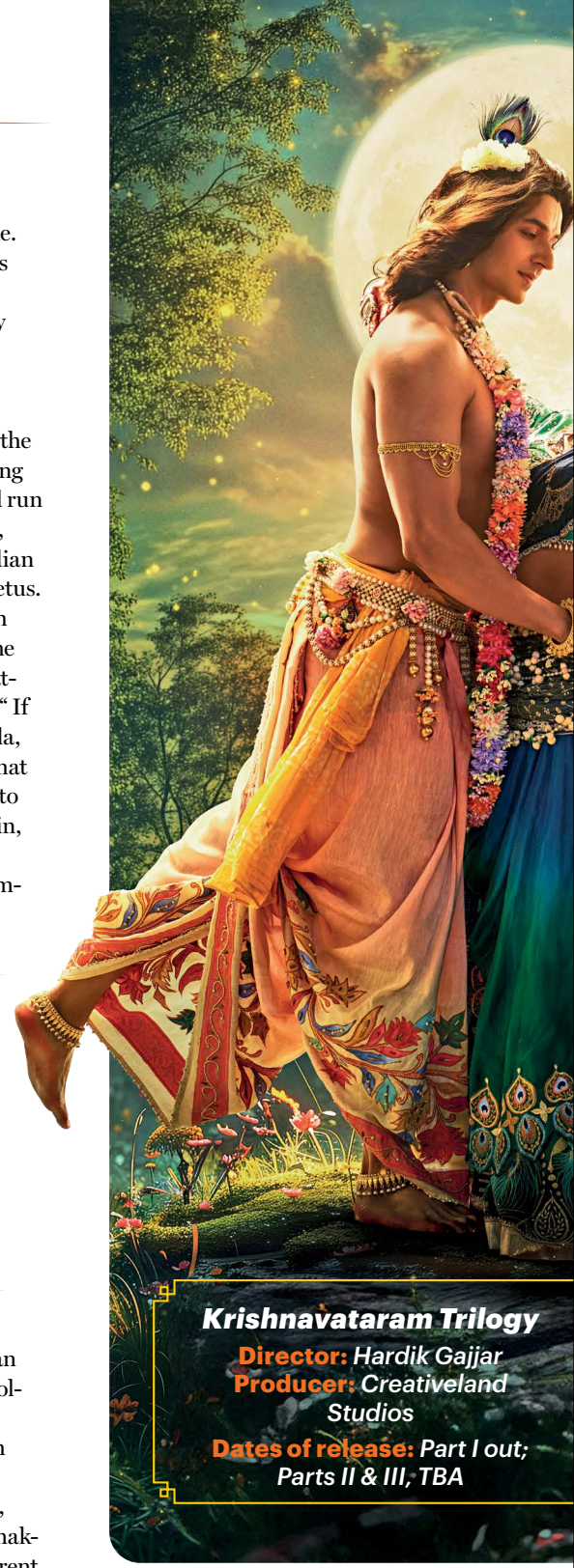
Hombale Films has already committed to making the Dashavatar franchise with Kumar. "India has an incredible wealth of folklore, mythology and traditions, and we believe these stories deserve to be told with the scale and cinematic experience they deserve," says Chaluve Gowda, co-founder of Hombale Films. In making six additional films on the different avatars of Vishnu and releasing them at two-year intervals, Kumar also wants to show children that Hindu gods are no less, if not better, than Marvel superheroes. "If we don't bring back our gods [on the big screen], kids will be habituated to western icons like Spider-Man, Superman and Batman," he says. "In the West, they have to concoct superheroes. We don't have to do that, for we have our gods." The franchise, he says, enables him to not just showcase the "valour" of our gods, but also familiarise Gens Alpha and Z with concepts such as dharma, righteousness, sacrifice and the value of family.

Hombale Films are not the only



**"In the West, they have to concoct superheroes. We don't have to do that; we have our gods. We need to show their valour so that kids know what sacrifice, righteousness and dharma are"**

**Ashwin Kumar,** *Director,* Mahavatar Narsimha



***Krishnavataram Trilogy***

**Director:** *Hardik Gajjar*
**Producer:** *Creativeland Studios*
**Dates of release:** *Part I out; Parts II & III, TBA*